Despite their similar world-affirming beliefs and emphasis on pleasure and success in life, the Tantrics also differed from the materialist Carvakas. The Tantrics worshipped (frequently female) deities, had magical rituals and practised yoga and meditation. However, as part of their non-dualistic world view, they strived to break down the walls of social convention, often through transgressive practices. They were religious but tended to oppose both caste and patriarchy. So, in some ways, despite their differences, moderate Tantrics may have got along well enough with the Carvakas.

Tantra also had many sects with differing beliefs and methods: Pashupata, Kaula, Kalamukha, Nathapanthi, Siddhanta, Sahajiya, Ganapatya, Kapalika, etc. They differed on many fronts: being less or more ritualistic, less or more invested in magic and alchemy, less or more into sexual–yogic practices, less or more permissive about drink and meat, and so on. One might as well classify them as *mild*, *moderate* and *extreme*.

In *mild* forms, spanning goddess worship and meditative practices, Tantric ideas broadly pervaded all Hindu, Buddhist and Jain sects. A *moderate* Tantric sect was the Shaiva Siddhanta, whose deity Sadasiva, a form of Shiva, was eminent at Khajuraho and appears often on its temple walls. Moderate Tantrics socially interacted with and lived among the masses. Shaiva Kapalika (*kapala* means ‘skull’) was an *extreme* Tantric sect, whose members lived aloof and solitary lives, hated Brahmins and habitually used a Brahmin’s empty skull as an eating or begging bowl. No wonder the Brahmins hated them back. The Kapalikas pursued ‘practices associated with cremation-grounds and polluting substances linked to sex and death’,[46] as well as ritual transgressions, animal sacrifices (perhaps even human sacrifices), consumption of meat, intoxicants, ingesting sexual fluids and more (the modern sect of Aghori sadhus is believed to have descended from the Kapalikas). These extreme sects were seen as antisocial sorcerers and libertines and were usually feared and despised.

Since most Tantric sects associated sex with magical power, Tantric gurus attracted wealthy and royal acolytes, who were drawn to their supposedly superhuman abilities to confer sexual vigour and youth through their ‘knowledge of alchemy, aphrodisiacs and magical *mantras* for mastery over women’.[47] In theory, Tantric sexual practices had higher spiritual ends but many pleasure-loving aristocrats—and their obliging gurus—reduced it